commanding the forces that marched into Bangladesh was a Sikh (General J. S. Aurora), and the general flown in to negotiate the surrender of the Pakistani forces in East Bengal was Jewish (Major-General J. F. R. Jacob). They led the armed forces of an overwhelmingly Hindu country.

That is India.

HINDU NATIONALISM

So the idea of India is of one land embracing many. As I have written before, it is the idea that a nation may endure differences of caste, creed, colour, culture, cuisine, conviction, costume and custom, and still rally around a consensus. That consensus is around the simple principle that in a diverse democracy you don't really need to agree—except on the ground rules of how you will disagree. The reason India has survived all the stresses and strains that have beset it for seventy years, and that led so many to predict its imminent disintegration, is that it maintained consensus on how to manage without consensus.

But the twentieth-century politics of deprivation has eroded Indian culture's confidence. As we have seen, Hindu chauvinism has emerged from the competition for resources in a contentious democracy. Politicians of all faiths across India seek to mobilise voters by appealing to narrow identities; by courting votes in the name of religion, caste and region, they have urged voters to define themselves on these lines. As religion, caste and region have come to dominate public discourse, to some it has become more important to be a Muslim, a Bodo or a Yadav than to be an Indian.

For Hindutva thinkers, the principles of tolerance and acceptance are emasculating. 'It is no longer enough for Hindus to be apostles of tolerance with no clear principles or doctrines with which to sustain it', argues Frawley. 'They must stand for the truth, which cannot always be popular, and not simply seek to placate everyone'.[2] But their truth is built on the denial of the truths that Hindus have lived by for millennia.

This is why the development of what has been called 'Hindu fundamentalism' and the resultant change in the public discourse about Indianness is so dangerous. The suggestion that only a Hindu, and only a